from Akbar to Abdullah Khan which must have caused much rumination and introspection on the part of the Uzbek. ‘What you have written with a pen perfumed with brotherhood on the subject of our mutually exerting ourselves to strengthen the foundations of peace,’ wrote the Hindustani Padshah, ‘and to purify the fountains of concord, and of making this Hind Koh the boundary between us, has most fully commended itself to us.’ The details of the ‘exertions’ that Akbar had made to strengthen his borders would have been conveyed by the Turani ambassador in worrisome detail.

Abdullah Khan Uzbek was right to be nervous about Akbar’s actions, for the Mughal Padshah had just pushed the north-west frontier of the empire from the Indus, where it earlier lay, further than it had ever been. This vast and porous frontier, from the Oxus to the Beas, had only been tenuously held by successive Indian rulers. The challenges for a secure command of the area were daunting.

> The Punjab rivers were all fordable except during the season of inundations. The Indus too was difficult to defend during the winter and early summer with its long course and broad channels in the Plains. The Salt Range is really formed of low hills that could be penetrated at any number of points. To the West of the Indus, the Sulaiman Range…is pierced by numerous passes open throughout the year, for another, it was inhabited by Afghan tribes who made regular garrisoning of all the passes by any outside army impossible. A truly ‘scientific frontier’ in medieval conditions could be secured only if an Indian Government held the Hindu Kush mountains.

Now, at last, Akbar had secured the Hindu Kush and though Abdullah Khan Uzbek had captured Badakhshan and Balkh, he would venture no further. Akbar also stoutly defended his credentials as an Islamic leader, assuring the Uzbek that ‘places which from the time of [the] rise of the sun of Islam till the present day had not been trod by the horse-hoofs of world-conquering princes and where their swords had never flashed, have become the dwelling-places and the homes of the faithful’. Akbar realized the importance of reassuring the Uzbek leader, and not isolating himself among the celebrated Muslim empires of the world. Aware that scandalous whispers may have sliced through the Khyber Pass about the unorthodox texture of the Mughal court, Akbar claimed that ‘the churches and temples of the infidels and heretics have become mosques and holy shrines for the